

From Silence to Strength: Bihar's menstrual health revolution

For too long, a girl's period was something she had to hide. **Whispers** in classrooms. **Embarrassed glances** at homes. Silence where there should have been support.

But in Bihar today, that **silence is breaking** — and what's **taking its place** is powerful. **Menstrual hygiene**, once **tucked away** at the **fringes** of public policy and social conversation, **is** now entering our schools, community halls, Government offices, and most importantly, our homes. We're seeing a cultural shift — one that doesn't just improve access to pads or sanitation but fundamentally changes how we treat our girls and women.

This change matters. Because when girls can manage their periods with **dignity**, they stay in school. When women have access to proper hygiene, they **show up** fully — to work, to lead, to live. When communities understand **menstruation** without shame, the **ripple effects** reach education, health, gender equality, and ultimately, the kind of society we want to build. This is more than just hygiene. It's about justice. Progress is visible.

Under the Govt. of India's Menstrual Hygiene Scheme (MHS), and its dedicated implementation by Govt. of Bihar departments, **the number** of young women using hygienic methods in Bihar **has** nearly doubled in recent years — from just 31per cent (NFHS-4) to almost 59per cent (NFHS-5).

This is better compared to the national average improvement from 57.6per cent to 77.3per cent. That's not a **statistic** — it's a sign of our collective effort: from frontline ASHA workers and teachers to mothers, fathers, and girls themselves. But let's be clear: we are not done.

A recent Sulabh Sanitation Mission study (2023-24) in Khagaria and Katihar reveals the harder truth — more than half the women surveyed lacked adequate menstrual materials during their last cycle, and 62per cent had no safe place to **dispose of** them. These numbers speak not only to a gap in services but to something deeper: a lack of choice, a lack of dignity, a lack of voice. That's why Bihar's Menstrual Health Management Road Map (2022-25) isn't just another policy. It's a promise — a **coordinated**, cross-sector **commitment** to treat menstrual health not as a side issue, but as central to our vision of an **equitable** Bihar. This means health departments working with education, rural development **teaming up** with sanitation, and everyone — from Government officials to local leaders — treating menstrual dignity as a priority, not an **afterthought**.

Real change is happening at the ground level. With UNICEF's support, we've introduced Saheli Kaksh — safe spaces in schools where girls can rest, change, and manage their periods with comfort and confidence.

Over 50 Government **schools** in Araria and Purnia now **host** these rooms, and more are on the way. But safe spaces must go beyond **brick and mortar** — they must live in the attitudes of teachers, classmates, and community leaders. We're also **aligning** existing schemes like the Mukhyamantri

Kanya Utthan Yojana and RKSK **with** our menstrual health goals. These programs have potential — but only if **last-mile** delivery becomes more **accountable** and more responsive. The **gap** between policy and people **must** close. And let's not forget this isn't just a "women's issue." Men and boys, fathers and brothers, teachers and panchayat leaders — every **voice** matters. When they **step up**, listen, and support, they help **dismantle** shame and build trust. That's what inclusion looks like. We must ensure that every Anganwadi has staff trained to support adolescent girls, that every health worker knows how to speak about menstruation with **empathy** and confidence, and that every school treats periods as a part of life, not a reason to leave class. The roadmap shall evolve. The programs shall deliver. And we shall keep listening to the girls whose lives we **seek** to change. Because this isn't just about managing a biological process. It's about unlocking potential, ensuring equality, and fighting for a future where no girl is **held back** by something as natural as her period. **[Practice Exercise]**

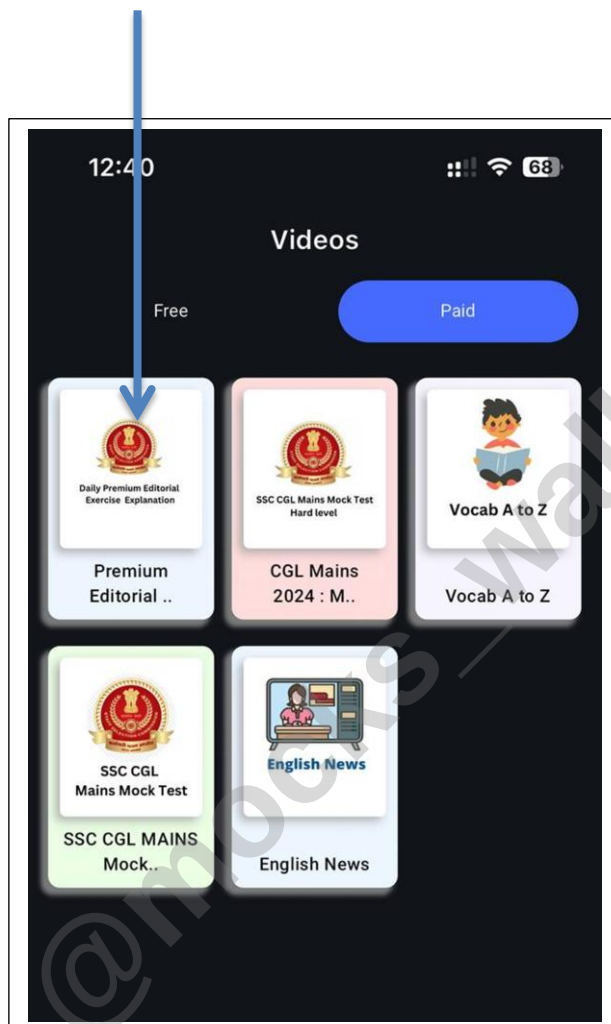
- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Whisper** (noun) – murmur, hush, murmurings, low voice, soft tone
फुसफुसाहट
2. **Embarrassed** (adjective) – ashamed, awkward, self-conscious, uncomfortable, flustered शर्मिदा
3. **Glance** (at) (noun) – look, glimpse, peek, view, gaze झलक / नज़र
4. **Break a silence** (phrase) – speak out, open up, raise voice, end quiet, give voice चुप्पी तोड़ना
5. **Take place** (phrase) – happen, occur, transpire, unfold, be held घटित होना
6. **Tuck away** (phrasal verb) – hide, conceal, stow, keep secret, obscure छुपाना / अलग रखना
7. **Fringe** (noun) – edge, margin, periphery, border, outskirts किनारा
8. **Dignity** (noun) – self-respect, honour, pride, nobility, decency गरिमा / सम्मान
9. **Show up** (phrasal verb) – appear, arrive, participate, turn up, be present सामने आना
10. **Menstruation** (noun) – periods, monthly cycle, menses, flow, menstrual cycle मासिक धर्म
11. **Ripple effect** (noun) – the continuing and spreading results of an event or action.
श्रृंखलाबद्ध प्रभाव
12. **Statistic** (noun) – data point, figure, number, metric, measurement आँकड़ा
13. **Dispose** (of) (verb) – discard, throw away, get rid of, eliminate, dump निपटान करना
14. **Coordinated** (adjective) – organized, unified, aligned, integrated, systematic समन्वित
15. **Commitment** (noun) – promise, dedication, pledge, obligation, responsibility प्रतिबद्धता
16. **Equitable** (adjective) – fair, just, impartial, balanced, unbiased न्यायसंगत
17. **Team up** (phrasal verb) – collaborate, cooperate, join forces, partner, work together मिलकर काम करना
18. **Afterthought** (noun) – second thought, later idea, add-on, reconsideration, postscript – बाद की सोच / बाद में जोड़ा गया विचार
19. **Host** (verb) – accommodate, organize, hold, provide space for, arrange आयोजित करना
20. **Brick and mortar** (noun) – buildings, typically housing. इमारत

21. **Align** (with) (verb) – match, coordinate, sync, integrate, harmonize मेल खाना
22. **Last-mile** (adjective) – final-stage, grassroots, end-point, delivery-level, outreach-level अंतिम चरण का
23. **Accountable** (adjective) – responsible, answerable, liable, obligated, transparent उत्तरदायी
24. **Voice** (verb) – express, state, articulate, speak out, declare व्यक्त करना
25. **Step up** (phrasal verb) – rise to the occasion, take initiative, act, volunteer, increase efforts सक्रिय होना
26. **Dismantle** (verb) – break down, remove, eliminate, deconstruct, undo हटाना
27. **Empathy** (noun) – compassion, understanding, sensitivity, kindness, concern सहानुभूति
28. **Seek** (verb) – strive for, pursue, aim for, request, look for प्रयास करना
29. **Hold back** (phrasal verb) – restrain, prevent, stop, hinder, delay रोकना

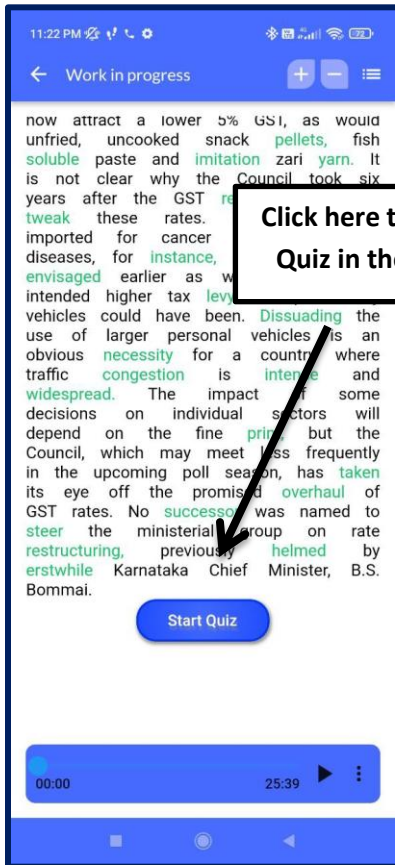
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



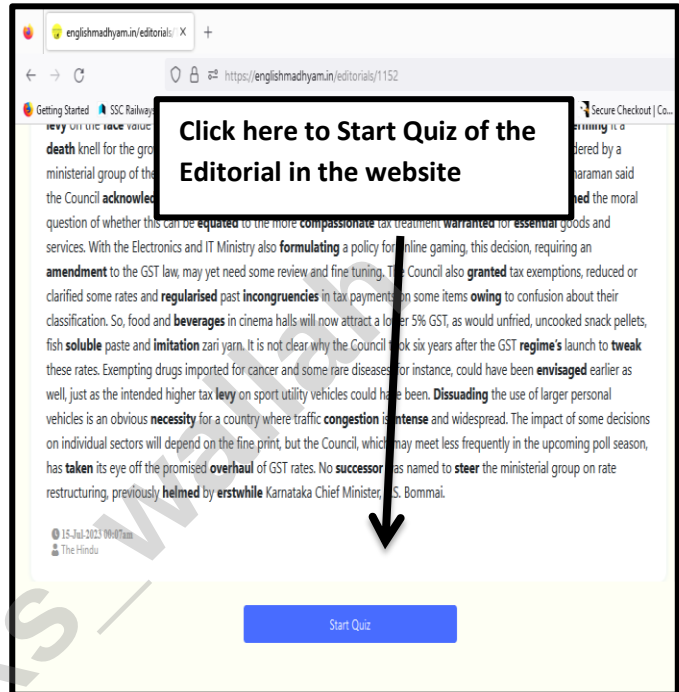
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Breaking the Silence** – Bihar is witnessing a cultural shift where menstruation is no longer hidden or shamed but openly discussed and addressed.
2. **Menstrual Hygiene in Focus** – What was once ignored in public policy is now a central issue in schools, homes, and government efforts.
3. **Impact on Girls and Women** – Access to menstrual hygiene enables girls to stay in school and women to participate fully in life and work.
4. **Bigger Than Hygiene** – The issue is tied to education, health, gender equality, and societal progress — making it a matter of justice.
5. **Government Efforts** – Under the Menstrual Hygiene Scheme (MHS), Bihar has seen significant improvement in hygienic practices among young women.
6. **Statistical Progress** – Usage of hygienic menstrual methods in Bihar increased from 31% (NFHS-4) to nearly 59% (NFHS-5), showing stronger growth than the national average.
7. **Collective Action** – This success is the result of combined efforts by ASHA workers, teachers, families, and communities.
8. **Persistent Gaps** – A 2023–24 study in Khagaria and Katihar reveals that many women still lack menstrual materials and safe disposal options.
9. **Deeper Challenges** – These issues highlight not just service gaps but also problems of dignity, voice, and choice.
10. **Road Map with Vision** – Bihar's Menstrual Health Management Road Map (2022–25) is a cross-sector commitment to menstrual dignity and equity.
11. **Interdepartmental Coordination** – Health, education, rural development, and sanitation departments are collaborating to implement this vision.
12. **Saheli Kaksh Initiative** – Safe spaces for girls in schools (like in Araria and Purnia) are being created for managing periods with comfort and dignity.
13. **Policy Alignment** – Schemes like Mukhyamantri Kanya Utthan Yojana and RKSK are being aligned with menstrual health objectives.
14. **Inclusive Participation** – Men and boys are being included in the conversation to break stigma and foster support.
15. **Vision for the Future** – The ultimate goal is to empower every girl, treat periods as normal, and ensure that no girl is held back by menstruation.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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